

Week 1 | August 16

Who Knows and How

Revelation and authority

The question: How does God let himself be known, and when Christians disagree about what he said, who settles it?

The one thing to land: Every Christian tradition in this room reads the same Bible. The disagreements are not usually about what the text says. They are about who has standing to say what it means.

The hour

5:30	Welcome, house rule, the January note, opening question, video
5:40	Movement 1: how anybody knows anything about God
5:50	Movement 2: where we stand
6:00	Movement 3: where they stand, and the creeds question
6:10	Discussion
6:28	Close

Week one runs two minutes long on the front end because of the housekeeping. Take it out of movement three.

Open (10 minutes)

Housekeeping, and only tonight. State the house rule. Then name the overlap with the winter series before anyone notices it on their own. Something close to: in January we asked what makes us us and answered it from the inside. This fall we are asking the same questions from the outside, with three traditions in the room who read the same book and land somewhere else. And tonight we start further back than January ever went.

The opening question: *How do you know anything about God at all?*

Take three answers. They will say the Bible. Push once, gently. Where did the Bible come from, and how would a person know it was worth trusting before they read it? Do not resolve it. That question is the hour.

Video: “What Is the Bible?” (5:48), How to Read the Bible series.
bibleproject.com/videos/what-is-the-bible

Why this one: it describes the Bible as a library assembled over centuries by a community, which is exactly the ground tonight's authority question stands on, and it does it without taking a denominational side.

After the video, ask: *What in that surprised you about how we actually got this book?* Take two answers, then move.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | How anybody knows anything about God

This is the genuinely new material. January covered the Bible and covered the church. It never covered revelation itself.

God is not available for inspection. Anything anyone knows about God is known because God chose to make it known. Christians have historically split that into two.

General revelation. What creation and conscience disclose to anyone anywhere. Psalm 19 and Romans 1. It is enough to leave a person without excuse and not enough to tell you God's name.

Special revelation. What God discloses particularly, in Israel, in Scripture, and finally and fully in Jesus Christ. Christ is the revelation. Scripture is the witness to it.

Wesleyans are comfortable with general revelation in a way some Protestants are not, and that comfort is downstream of prevenient grace, which arrives in week three. God is already at work in a person before the church ever shows up. Plant that sentence tonight and collect on it in two weeks.

Read as you go: Psalm 19:1-4, then Romans 1:18-23.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | Where we stand

Scripture is primary, read with tradition, reason, and experience.

Say plainly that the Quadrilateral is a twentieth-century label, Albert Outler's, for a pattern in Wesley, and that it does not mean four equal legs. Scripture is primary. The other three are how it gets read. A room full of Methodists has heard the word and most of them have the proportions wrong.

Then the claim worth the time. Scripture's authority is not self-enacting. The church did not receive a finished Bible and submit to it. The church recognized these books, named them primary, and then bound itself to what it named. Authority runs through the church to Scripture, and the church holds itself under the Scripture it made primary.

Read: Acts 15:1-21. Name it as you go. The first Christian doctrinal fight was settled by a council, and the letter that came out of it says the decision seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to them.

Also worth ninety seconds: we have doctrinal standards most Methodists have never read. The Articles of Religion, the Confession of Faith, Wesley's Sermons, his Notes on the New Testament. They are protected by the Restrictive Rules and cannot simply be voted away. We are not a church without doctrine. We are a church whose people do not know its doctrine.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | Where they stand

Roman Catholic. Scripture and Tradition as two channels of one divine revelation, with the Magisterium interpreting both authoritatively. Vatican II's *Dei Verbum* is the modern statement. The practical upshot is what nobody else has, a living office that can settle a disputed question and expect to be obeyed. *The generous version:* somebody has to decide, and a church that cannot decide anything will eventually believe everything.

Southern Baptist and non-denominational. Sola scriptura in a stronger form than the Reformed hold it, plus soul competency, the conviction that every believer stands before God and the text without a human mediator, plus the instinct that a church should have no creed but the Bible. Even the Baptist Faith and Message calls itself a consensus statement rather than a binding creed, and that wording is deliberate. *The generous version:* every layer you put between a person and Scripture is a layer that can go wrong, and church history supplies the examples.

Reformed and Calvinist. Sola scriptura also, Scripture as final judge over all tradition, but read through confessions that genuinely bind officers. Westminster, Heidelberg, Dort. A Presbyterian pastor takes vows to a confession. It is not Scripture and it is not optional either. *The generous version:* a confession is a church being honest about what it has already concluded, written where everyone can see it and hold it accountable.

Then the sharpest thing in the hour, and nobody teaches it. Put the four side by side on creeds. Rome has a magisterium. The Reformed have binding confessions. The Baptists have neither, on principle. We have standards that are protected and unread.

On screen (2 minutes). Open the **genealogy view** at theologycompare.vercel.app and walk the branching quickly, early church to 1054 to 1517 and out. Do not teach it. Just let them see that the four traditions in tonight's conversation are relatives with a traceable family tree. Then say the site is theirs for the next six weeks and move on.

Discussion (18 minutes)

Open with: *Where did you first learn how to read the Bible, and whose interpretation were you handed without knowing it?*

Everyone can answer this from their own life and it goes straight to the night's subject. It is the best opener in the series.

Then choose from these.

- Make the Catholic case as if you held it. What is it protecting that we might be leaving unprotected?
- When your Bible study lands on a verse and two people read it opposite ways, what actually happens next in the room? Not what should happen. What does.
- Is there anything you believe about God that you learned from creation or from conscience rather than from Scripture?
- If our doctrinal standards are legally protected and nobody has read them, are they doing any work at all?
- What is something you were taught the Bible clearly says, that you later found out was not so clear?
- Who has changed your mind about a passage of Scripture, and what made you willing to let them?

Hold in reserve, for the last ten minutes: *If the church is what recognized these books as Scripture, what keeps the church from simply changing its mind later?*

That is the real question under the whole night and it is worth the time. The Wesleyan answer is self-binding rather than an external brake. The church holds itself under the Scripture it made primary, and it is accountable to holiness, to unity, and to whether the fruit of the Spirit is actually showing up. Do not rush to give that answer. Let them try first.

Close (2 minutes)

Tonight was the foundation. Everything for five more weeks is built on the question of who gets to say what Christianity means, and every tradition we look at answers it differently before it answers anything else.

Between now and next Sunday

Ten minutes. Watch "The Story of the Bible" (5:38) at bibleproject.com. Then sit with one question: if the Bible is one story rather than a collection of rules, what changes about how you would settle a disagreement from it?

Thirty minutes. Read the Articles of Religion in Part III of the Book of Discipline, free at umc.org. Most Methodists have never read the doctrine

they are officially committed to. It takes about twenty minutes and it is a strange and clarifying experience.

Go deeper. Read the first chapter of Adam Hamilton's *Christianity's Family Tree*. Then go to theologybot.vercel.app, open the Authority node, and read the page. Ask the bot: "Has Woods always taught that the church confers Scripture's authority?" and see what it pulls up.

Bring back: one question about the Bible you have never felt comfortable asking out loud in a church building.

Watch out for

Someone will hear "the church gave Scripture its authority" as "the church is above the Bible." Have the answer ready and short. The church recognized what God had given and then bound itself to it, and a church that thinks it can unbind itself has misunderstood what it did.

The other risk is week one running long. You have housekeeping, a video, and the densest material in the series. If you are behind at 6:05, cut the doctrinal-standards paragraph rather than the discussion.

Week 2 | August 23

How Many Gods Are There?

Trinity, Christology, and the Spirit's activity

The question: Christians say there is one God and then talk about three. Which is it?

The one thing to land: On this one, the three traditions we compare ourselves to all night are on our side. Tonight we find out what the family actually has in common, and where the edge of the family actually runs.

The structural note, for you and not the room

Catholic, Southern Baptist, and Reformed all confess Nicaea. Run the standing three tonight and you get four identical cells. So tonight the comparison changes shape on purpose, and you say so out loud. That move is itself the teaching point. The doctrine of God is where the line between a Christian tradition and something else actually falls, and it is worth showing people that the line exists and where it runs.

The hour

5:30	Opening question and video
5:38	Movement 1: the problem, and what the church actually said
5:48	Movement 2: why it matters, and where we lean
5:58	Movement 3: the edge of the family, and the Spirit
6:08	Discussion
6:28	Close

Open (8 minutes)

The opening question: *If a fourteen-year-old asked you to explain the Trinity in one minute, what would you say?*

Let two or three people try. Let it be awkward, and be warm about it. Then say plainly that most of the analogies we reach for, water and ice and steam, the three-leaf clover, one man who is a father and a son and a husband, are each a position the church named and rejected centuries ago. That lands hard, it is true, and it buys you the whole hour.

Video: “God” (8:10), Biblical Themes series.

bibleproject.com/videos/god

Why this one: it is the closest thing BibleProject has to a Trinity video, and it does the hard part well. It works through how Scripture presents God as one while speaking of the Father, the Son, and the Spirit, and it stays in the text rather than jumping to the creeds.

After the video, ask: *Did anything in that feel like it was solving the problem, or did it feel like it was describing it more carefully?* Take two answers.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | The problem, and what the church actually said

Start where Israel started. **Read Deuteronomy 6:4.** One God. That is the ground and it never moves.

Then **read John 1:1-18** and **Philippians 2:5-11** and let the tension sit. The New Testament writers are Jewish monotheists who keep saying things about Jesus that a Jewish monotheist should not be able to say.

Then the vocabulary, in plain words before the technical ones.

Not modalism. God is not one person wearing three hats at different times. At the Jordan the Son is in the water, the Spirit descends, the Father speaks. All three at once.

Not three gods. One God. Three persons of one substance, coeternal.

Fully God and fully human in Christ, which Chalcedon settled, and which matters because only God can save and only a human can stand in for humans.

Say the Nicene Creed together. Most of the room says it in worship and has never been told what fight it settled.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | Why it matters, and where we lean

Take the question a thoughtful person actually has, which is not “is this coherent” but “why should I care.”

Because the Trinity is the claim that God is not a lonely monad who created us out of need. Love, relationship, and self-giving are what God is before creation exists, not roles God took up afterward. And because the incarnation means God did not send a representative. God came.

Then the Wesleyan accent, and be honest that we are not distinctive here. Methodists confess what the whole church confesses. Where we lean is toward the Spirit’s present and ongoing work, and toward the Trinity as a life you are invited into rather than a puzzle you are asked to solve. Wesley

preached the witness of the Spirit as something a person actually experiences.

Read John 16:12-15 and Matthew 28:16-20.

On screen (2 minutes). The site cannot do this yet.

theologycompare.vercel.app has ten doctrine rows and the doctrine of God is not one of them, so there is nothing to point at. A brief has gone to Claude Code to add it, along with the four groups outside the Nicene consensus and a continuationist-to-cessationist axis for the Spirit.

Use the **Nicene Line** sheet instead. Project it, or print it and hold it up. It shows the eight families inside one band of agreement, then a rule, then the four groups on the other side of it, which is exactly the picture this moment needed. Say plainly that the row does not exist on the site yet and that you are having it built, because the handout in their hands points them at a doctrine matrix row that is not there. Owning that takes ten seconds and it models the honesty the whole class runs on.

If you would rather use the live site anyway, **Authors and leaders** is the one view that pays off tonight. Athanasius sits in the Orthodox column, described as the defender of Nicaea. After the explainer, that is a satisfying place to land.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | The edge of the family, and the Spirit

First, the groups who answer differently. These are neighbors with names, so watch your tone. The room will follow your tone rather than your instruction.

- **Oneness Pentecostals.** One God revealed in three modes rather than existing as three persons, and baptism in Jesus' name only. This is modalism, which the church named and rejected in the third century. Sincere and serious Christians on nearly every other question.
- **Latter-day Saints.** Father, Son, and Spirit as three separate beings united in purpose, an embodied Father, and an open canon with additional scripture. The largest departure on the list.
- **Jehovah's Witnesses.** Christ as the first and highest created being rather than eternal God. This is Arianism, which is precisely the position Nicaea was called to answer. The creed the room recited half an hour ago was written against this.
- **Unitarian and progressive.** The divinity of Christ treated as one interpretive option among several.

Then the Spirit, where the disagreement runs through the standing three rather than between them. Continuationist and cessationist. The Reformed column is largely cessationist, holding the sign gifts ceased with the apostolic age. The non-denominational column is often continuationist

and sometimes fully charismatic. Rome has its own charismatic renewal. And the Assemblies of God, which is all over this county, holds speaking in tongues as the initial physical evidence of Spirit baptism.

Where we land: open to the Spirit's ongoing work, and unwilling to make any single gift the test of whether a person has the Spirit. Say why that is a position rather than a dodge. Wesley expected the Spirit to do something in a person and refused to make one particular manifestation the proof of it.

Discussion (20 minutes)

Open with: *Which analogy for the Trinity had you been using, and how attached to it are you now?*

Light, universal, and it gets the room laughing at itself in the first ninety seconds, which is worth a great deal in week two.

Then choose from these.

- Have you had a conversation with a Mormon or a Jehovah's Witness at your door? How did it go, and what would you do differently now?
- What breaks if Jesus is not fully God? What breaks if he is not fully human? Take them one at a time.
- Have you ever been made to feel you were missing something because you had not had a particular spiritual experience? What did that do to you?
- What does it change for you to know that Catholics, Baptists, Presbyterians, and Methodists all agree about tonight's topic?
- When have you actually noticed the Holy Spirit doing something? Not a doctrine. A moment.
- Where is the line between a Christian who is wrong about something and a group that is teaching a different faith, and who gets to draw it?

Hold in reserve: *If the doctrine of God is the one thing the whole family agrees on, why do we spend so much more energy on the things we do not?*

That question quietly frames the remaining four weeks and it is worth ending on.

Close (2 minutes)

Everything from here on is a family argument. Tonight was the floor everybody stands on. Starting next week we start finding out how far apart the furniture is.

Between now and next Sunday

Ten minutes. Watch “Holy Spirit” (4:11) at bibleproject.com/videos/holy-spirit. Then one question: where in your own life would you say the Spirit has actually been at work, and how would you know?

Thirty minutes. Read the Nicene Creed slowly, one line at a time, and look up what each line was written to rule out. The Book of Worship has the text and any basic commentary online has the history. It is a fighting document and it reads completely differently once you know that.

Go deeper. Watch “Son of Man” (5:51) at bibleproject.com/videos/son-of-man, then open the Christology and God nodes on theologybot.vercel.app and read both pages. Ask the bot: “What has Woods preached about the Trinity?”

Bring back: one question you have actually been asked by someone from another faith that you did not know how to answer.

Watch out for

This is the week the class could turn into a cult-comparison hour with a mean edge. Do not let it. Accuracy and kindness at the same time, or the whole series loses its credibility in week two.

The second risk is spending twenty minutes on Mormons because it is interesting and five on the Spirit because it is harder. The Spirit material is the part that touches people in this county every week.

Week 3 | August 30

Who Gets Saved and How

Election, the will, prevenient grace, and the extent of the atonement

The question: Does God choose, or do you?

The one thing to land: Both answers are protecting something real. Ours protects the genuineness of the invitation. Theirs protects the fact that salvation is God's work rather than our achievement. Understand what the other side is guarding and the disagreement stops being stupid.

Say the seam at the top

Tonight is **who**. Next week is **what**. Tonight asks who the offer is for and how a person can say yes. Next week asks what actually happened at the cross and what actually happens inside a person. Thirty seconds spent on that division now saves twenty minutes of drift later.

The hour

5:30	Opening question and video
5:38	Movement 1: the texts that cut both ways
5:48	Movement 2: prevenient grace, and what it costs us
5:58	Movement 3: the Reformed case at full strength, and the Baptist split
6:08	Discussion
6:28	Close

Open (8 minutes)

The opening question: *Has God already decided who will be saved?*

Ask for a show of hands, and let people look around. This is the question in the series most likely to have quietly divided the people sitting next to each other, and most of them do not know it yet. Name that out loud in a friendly way. It is the whole reason tonight is interesting.

Video: "Covenants" (5:46), Biblical Themes series.

bibleproject.com/videos/covenants

Why this one, and it fits better than it looks. Tonight's argument is about God choosing, and in Scripture the choosing starts with Abraham. The video

walks the covenants and shows that every time God picks somebody, he picks them *for* something, a job on behalf of everybody else. That reframe is the most useful thing you can put in the room before the argument starts, because most people arrive assuming election is a list of who is in. Hearing it as vocation rather than as a roster changes the temperature of the whole hour.

BibleProject has no video on election, and that is deliberate. They stay out of the Calvinist and Arminian question. Which is exactly why this one works: it hands you the biblical ground everybody shares, before the traditions start disagreeing on top of it.

After the video, ask: *In the Bible, when God chooses somebody, what does he choose them for?* Take two answers and go.

Alternate if you want a different angle: “Image of God” (6:17), bibleproject.com/videos/image-of-god, on the vocation humanity was made for and forfeited. Use it if your room needs the will rather than election as the way in.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | The texts that cut both ways

Read the hard ones on both sides and do not stack the deck. This movement is where you earn the room’s trust for the rest of the night.

- **Ephesians 2:1-10.** Dead in trespasses, made alive, by grace through faith, not your own doing.
- **John 6:44.** No one can come unless the Father draws him.
- **Romans 9:6-24.** Jacob and Esau, the potter and the clay.
- **1 Timothy 2:3-6.** God desires everyone to be saved.
- **Titus 2:11.** The grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation to all.

Say out loud that Romans 9 is the strongest chapter in the Bible for the position we do not hold, and that any Methodist who has not wrestled with it has not done the work. Saying that buys you enormous credibility for movement three.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | Prevenient grace, and what it costs us

Three claims, in order.

Depravity is real. Wesleyans are not soft on sin. The Articles of Religion say a person cannot turn and prepare himself by his own natural strength. We agree with the Reformed on the diagnosis. Say that clearly, because most people in the room assume our disagreement starts earlier than it does.

Prevenient grace. The word means the grace that goes before. God is already at work in every person, before they ask, restoring enough freedom

to respond. Nobody comes to God on their own steam, and nobody is left without the ability to answer. This is the load-bearing wall of the whole Wesleyan system, and it is how you hold John 6:44 and 1 Timothy 2:4 in the same hand without flinching.

Therefore election is conditional and the atonement is unlimited.

God elects in view of foreseen faith. Christ died for everyone. Whosoever will.

Then the honest cost, and do not skip it. Our position makes the human response genuinely decisive, which means we have to explain why some respond and others do not without making the difference a matter of human merit. Wesley's answer is that even the response is enabled by grace, so nobody gets credit. Say it, and let the room feel that it is a real answer and also not the end of the conversation. Admitting the seam in your own position is what makes movement three land.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | The other three, with the Reformed case at full strength

Reformed and Calvinist. Total depravity, unconditional election, limited atonement, irresistible grace, perseverance of the saints. The Canons of Dort, written point by point against the Arminians, which means this system was built specifically against ours.

Give it its full strength and take your time. God's choice is free and unconditioned by anything in us. Salvation is entirely God's work from first to last. And the assurance that comes with that is enormous: if your salvation depends on your choosing, then on a bad day it depends on you, and if it depends on God's choosing, it never does.

That is the best argument in the series. The room should hear it made well, by you, without a wink.

Southern Baptist, and the column splits. The most useful thing in the hour, because it is happening in churches your people attend. The Baptist Faith and Message is worded so that both sides can sign it. The traditional Southern Baptist position is conditional election and unlimited atonement, functionally close to ours. The New Calvinist wing inside the same denomination holds every point of Dort. In 2012 a large group of Southern Baptists published a traditional statement specifically to push back on the Calvinist resurgence in their own convention. Two Southern Baptist churches on the same road may be on opposite sides of tonight's question and their members often do not know it.

Roman Catholic. Predestination affirmed and held together with genuine human freedom, with the tension left standing rather than solved. Rome has never required its people to pick a side, and Dominicans and Jesuits argued about it for centuries without either being condemned. That is itself a

position, and an interesting one. Some tensions may be better held than settled.

The point to draw out: three of the four traditions in the room refuse to resolve this fully. Only the Reformed system resolves it cleanly, which is both its great strength and the reason people leave it.

On screen (3 minutes). Use the **Who Gets Saved and How** sheet, which puts all four of tonight's questions on parallel spectrums with the traditions plotted on each. Project it, or hand out the printed version. The payoff is the vertical alignment. The order never changes, which shows the room that these are not four separate opinions but one conviction about who moves first, showing up four times. The gray bracket on every line is the Southern Baptist Convention spanning both of its wings, and that is the detail people in this county will feel.

Then open the **two-axis map** at theologycompare.vercel.app with grace and the will as the axes and mark the wall map. The site does this one well, and watching it scatter live lands differently than a printed sheet.

Discussion (20 minutes)

Open with: *Which of tonight's positions did you grow up with, whether or not anybody ever named it for you?*

Then choose from these.

- Make the Calvinist case as strongly as you can, out loud, right now. What is it protecting?
- How do you pray for someone who wants nothing to do with God? Does what we said tonight change the prayer?
- Does conditional election turn salvation into something you earn? Where exactly is the line?
- What do you do with Romans 9? Do not answer for anybody. Let them work.
- Has anyone here ever found the Calvinist answer comforting? What was going on when it comforted you?
- If God is already at work in every person before they know it, what should that change about how you talk to somebody far from church?

Hold in reserve: *If prevenient grace is real, then everyone you will meet this week has already been worked on by God before you got there. What would you do differently if you actually believed that on Tuesday?*

Close (2 minutes)

Tonight was who. Next week is what. Same salvation, different half of the question.

Between now and next Sunday

Ten minutes. Watch “Loyal Love” (5:11) at bibleproject.com/videos/loyal-love. Khesed is God’s covenant loyalty, given before it is deserved and kept when it is not returned, which is the biblical shape of prevenient grace without the Wesleyan vocabulary attached. Then read Luke 15:11-32 and ask who moves first, and how many times.

Thirty minutes. Read the Canons of Dort, free online, at least the first two heads of doctrine. Read them as the tradition’s own voice rather than as an opponent’s summary. It is the house rule practiced on the hardest possible case.

Go deeper. Read the first three chapters of Roger Olson’s *Against Calvinism*, then the first three of Michael Horton’s *For Calvinism*. Both, in that order or the other one. Then open the Grace and Salvation nodes on theologybot.vercel.app, and use the ask-and-compare box on theologycompare.vercel.app for “how does Methodist election differ from Reformed?”

Bring back: the name of someone you know who believes differently than you do about tonight’s question, and one thing you actually admire about their faith.

Watch out for

Do not let this become the hour where Calvinists get mocked. Some people in this room have family in Reformed churches and some have quietly found that system compelling and have never said so. One caricature costs you their trust for the rest of the series.

Also watch for the person who wants to relitigate Romans 9 for fifteen minutes. Name that it deserves its own evening, offer to have that evening, and move.

Week 4 | September 13

What the Cross Did

Atonement, justification, assurance, and whether you can lose it

The question: What actually happened on the cross, and what actually happens in a person who believes?

The one thing to land: The Wesleyan tradition has never made one theory of the atonement a test of orthodoxy. If you have privately never found penal substitution satisfying and assumed something was wrong with you, nothing is wrong with you.

Note the two-week gap

This is the first Sunday back after Labor Day weekend. Spend the first sixty seconds recapping week three in two sentences, because a fortnight is long enough that half the room has lost the thread and the seam between who and what is the whole reason tonight is a separate session.

The hour

5:30	Recap, opening question, video
5:40	Movement 1: the cross, and the theories nobody told you about
5:50	Movement 2: justification, and what actually changes in a person
6:00	Movement 3: assurance, and whether you can lose it
6:10	Discussion
6:28	Close

Open (10 minutes)

The opening question: *Why did Jesus have to die?*

Take four or five answers and write every one of them on the board. Correct none of them. Most of the room will give some version of “to pay for our sins,” because that is the only theory most American Christians have ever been taught. You are going to come back to that board in movement one, and the fact that the answers are already up there in their own words is what makes the point land.

Video: “Sacrifice and Atonement” (6:51), Biblical Themes series.
bibleproject.com/videos/sacrifice-and-atonement

Why this one: it works the sacrificial system from Leviticus forward and shows what the cross is drawing on, which is the layer underneath every theory the church later built. It also quietly declines to reduce the cross to a single transaction, which is exactly the point of movement one.

After the video, ask: *Did that match the answer you gave me two minutes ago?* Take two answers.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | The cross, and the theories nobody told you about

Go back to the board.

The church has never dogmatically defined *how* the cross saves, only *that* it does. There is no ecumenical council on the atonement the way there is on the Trinity. That surprises nearly everyone and it is simply true.

Walk the major theories quickly and fairly. Your Atonement Theories deck already has all of this.

- **Ransom and Christus Victor.** Christ defeats the powers that hold humanity captive. Dominant in the early church and in Eastern Orthodoxy, and recovering ground now.
- **Satisfaction.** Anselm. The debt is to God’s honor and Christ’s obedience is the offering.
- **Penal substitution.** The Reformers. Christ bears the penalty in our place.
- **Moral influence.** The cross as the demonstration of a love that changes those who see it.

The Wesleyan position is that these are complementary rather than competing and that no single one is a test of whether you are a Christian. Wesley preached substitution freely and he also preached the cross as love that transforms. He did not choose.

Read Isaiah 53:4-6 and Colossians 2:13-15 back to back and let the room hear that Scripture itself uses more than one picture.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | Justification, and what changes in a person

Read Romans 3:21-28.

By faith alone, joined to real inward change. Wesley’s line as you taught it in January: we are saved by faith alone, but not by a faith that is alone.

The distinction to make carefully, because it is the one people actually use later. Justification is what God does *for* you. New birth is what God begins to do *in* you. They happen in the same moment and they are not the same thing. Methodism refuses to collapse either into the other.

Where they stand. Rome puts righteousness infused rather than only declared, so a real change in the person is part of what justification means. The Reformed and Baptist columns put it forensic and imputed, a verdict declared. We keep the verdict and refuse to stop there.

Worth ninety seconds and almost nobody knows it. In 2006 the World Methodist Council formally associated itself with the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification, the agreement Lutherans and Catholics signed in 1999. Four hundred and fifty years of mutual anathemas over this doctrine, and the three largest Western traditions have now said in writing that the old condemnations do not describe what the others actually teach. Whatever else that is, it is a fact about the world your people live in, and it should change the temperature of an argument with a Catholic in-law.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | Assurance, and whether you can lose it

Read Romans 8:15-17, then Hebrews 6:4-8, then 1 John 5:11-13.

Wesley preached assurance as the Spirit's direct witness that you are God's child, and he taught that a person can know it rather than merely hope it. That is Romans 8:16 and it is a Methodist distinctive worth claiming.

And he taught that salvation can be forfeited. Not lost by accident and not revoked by God, but genuinely walked away from. That follows from everything in week three. If grace is resistible at the beginning, it stays resistible later.

The three-way, and it is genuinely three-way.

- **Rome.** Yes, you can lose it, through mortal sin, and it is restored through the church's ministry of reconciliation.
- **Reformed and Southern Baptist.** No. The elect persevere. The Baptist Faith and Message affirms that all true believers endure to the end, which is more careful than the bumper-sticker version. Anyone who falls away was never truly saved.
- **Us.** You can walk away and you can come home, and neither one is automatic.

Give the pastoral strength of eternal security honestly. It offers a settled peace our doctrine cannot offer in the same form, and people who have lived with religious anxiety find it genuinely liberating. Our answer has to be better than "that is wrong." Ours is that peace comes from the Spirit's witness rather than from a transaction you completed once, and that you are not the one holding the door open.

On screen (2 minutes). Open the **spectrum view** at theologycompare.vercel.app on salvation security and put it up. This is the single most-asked question in Baldwin County and seeing four traditions arranged on it is worth more than another paragraph from you. Mark the wall map.

Discussion (18 minutes)

Open with: *Which theory of the atonement were you taught, and did anybody ever tell you it was one of several?*

Then choose from these.

- Has “once saved, always saved” ever been a comfort to you? Has it ever been a problem?
- What is the difference between being declared righteous and being made righteous, and does the difference matter on a Tuesday?
- Wesley taught that you can know you are God’s child. Have you ever known that? What did it feel like, and what do you do in the stretches when you do not?
- If salvation can be forfeited, how would a person know if they had?
- Four hundred and fifty years of condemnation and then a signed agreement. What do you do with the fact that the church can be that wrong about each other for that long?
- What would you actually say to someone who told you they had gone too far to come back?

Hold in reserve, and land the hour here: *Is there anyone here who has been quietly afraid that they lost it?*

Only ask that if the room has earned it and you have time to sit in the answer. If you ask it, do not solve it quickly.

Close (2 minutes)

Do not end on mechanics. Leave the last two minutes on the door being open and on who is holding it.

Between now and next Sunday

Ten minutes. Read Luke 15 all the way through, all three parables in a row. One question: in each one, who does the searching?

Thirty minutes. Read the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification. It is short, it is free online, and it is one of the more remarkable documents of the last century. Then ask yourself what else we might be arguing about that we have not actually read.

Go deeper. Read Wesley's sermon "The Witness of the Spirit," free online. Then open the Atonement, Justification, and Assurance nodes on theologybot.vercel.app and read all three. Ask the bot: "Has Woods ever preached penal substitution?"

Bring back: a sentence about the cross you grew up hearing, that you now are not sure you believe.

Watch out for

This is the hour with the most pastoral risk in the series. Somebody in the room is quietly afraid they have lost it, and somebody else is quietly relieved that they cannot. Watch faces during movement three. Be available after.

Week 5 | September 20

Means and End

Sacraments and sanctification

The question: What is God actually doing at the font and at the table, and how far can grace take a person in this life?

The one thing to land: This is the week we are not in the middle. On Christian perfection, none of the three traditions we have been comparing ourselves to makes our claim.

The spine, and it is Wesley's own logic

These two topics are one session rather than two crammed together. The sacraments are the ordinary channels through which sanctifying grace comes. Holiness is what they are for. Means and end. Taught that way this is the most Wesleyan hour in the series, and the pairing will feel obvious to the room by 6:00.

The hour

5:30	Opening question and video
5:38	Movement 1: what a means of grace is, and the four models
5:48	Movement 2: the font and the table
5:58	Movement 3: holiness, and the week we are the outlier
6:08	Discussion
6:28	Close

Open (8 minutes)

The opening question: *When a baby gets baptized here, what just happened?*

The room will be less sure than they expect to be, and the uncertainty is the door. Do not rescue them.

Video: "Holiness" (6:35), Biblical Themes series.
bibleproject.com/videos/holiness

Why this one: it sets up the second half of the hour rather than the first, on purpose. It shows holiness as God's own life rather than as a behavior chart,

which is exactly the misunderstanding you have to clear before anyone can hear the word perfection without panicking.

After the video, ask: *Was holiness in that video mostly about behavior, or mostly about something else?* Take two answers and hold the thread until movement three.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | What a means of grace is, and the four models

Wesley's definition from Sermon 16, which you taught in January: outward signs, words, or actions ordained of God as the ordinary channels by which he conveys grace.

Two things hold together and both matter. Grace is truly given here, which is more than a symbol. And it is not automatic, which is less than a machine. Randy Maddox's name for the whole Wesleyan system is responsible grace, and this is where you can see why.

Reuse your four-model chart from January, and say you are reusing it. Calling back to a series people sat through reads as a throughline. Repeating it silently reads as running out of material.

- **Certain sacrament, model one:** Roman Catholic and Eastern Orthodox. The rite conveys grace when no obstacle is placed in the way.
- **Certain sacrament, model two:** Lutheran.
- **Symbolic testimony:** Baptist and Anabaptist. An ordinance rather than a sacrament, and the word choice is the entire argument.
- **Contingent sacrament:** Presbyterian, Reformed, Anglican, and us. Grace is genuinely offered and genuinely has to be received.

Point out the thing that surprises people: on this question the Presbyterians are with us and not with the Baptists. Most Methodists assume Presbyterians are Baptists with better music.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | The font and the table

Read Romans 6:1-4 and Acts 2:38-39.

Baptism. A means of grace. Infants are baptized because grace precedes response, which is prevenient grace applied with water, and it connects tonight straight back to week three. And it is not automatic, which is why the congregation makes vows. The promise has to be carried by somebody until the child can carry it.

Where they stand. Rome: a regenerating sacrament. The Reformed: a covenant sign in continuity with circumcision. Baptists: believer's baptism

only, by immersion, a public testimony to something that already happened, which is why they cannot count an infant baptism.

Read 1 Corinthians 11:23-29.

The table. A real presence without a defined mechanism. Rome defines it, with transubstantiation and the philosophical machinery to say how. Baptists call it a memorial. The Reformed hold a real spiritual presence received by faith. We affirm the presence and decline to explain it, which is either humility or evasion depending on who you ask, and the room should get to say which.

And the open table, which is a conviction rather than a technicality. Wesley called communion a converting ordinance, meaning it can be the thing that reaches a person rather than only the reward for having already been reached. We do not check credentials at the rail because we do not know who God is about to get hold of.

On screen (2 minutes). Pull the **doctrine matrix** at theologycompare.vercel.app and show the baptism and Lord's Supper rows side by side. These two rows are the most visible differences in the whole series and the ones people actually run into at a family funeral.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | Holiness, and the week we are the outlier

Change your posture here and say so. For four weeks we have landed between people. Tonight we do not.

Entire sanctification. Christian perfection. God's grace can so fill a person in this life that love of God and neighbor genuinely governs them.

Then immediately say what Wesley did not mean, because this is the most misunderstood Methodist claim there is, and an undefined word will do damage in under five minutes. Paraphrasing his repeated clarifications in *A Plain Account of Christian Perfection*: he did not mean freedom from ignorance, or from mistakes, or from bodily weakness, or from temptation. He meant perfection in love. A heart so filled with love for God and neighbor that nothing else holds the center.

And he framed it as going on to perfection, which is why the question is still asked of every ordinand at annual conference.

Read Matthew 5:43-48, then 1 Thessalonians 5:23-24, then 1 John 1:8-9. That last one is the honest counterweight and you should read it rather than let someone else raise it.

Where they stand, and this is the part to slow down on.

- **Roman Catholic.** Growth in infused grace over a lifetime, aided by the sacraments, and finished after death rather than here.

- **Reformed.** Progressive, real, lifelong, and never completed in this life.
- **Southern Baptist.** Progressive growth, and in practice the emphasis often falls so heavily on the moment of conversion that what comes after gets less attention than it deserves.

All three agree it does not finish here. We are the outlier. Say that plainly, then hand the room the honest question and let them have it.

Discussion (20 minutes)

Open with: *Do you remember your own baptism? If not, does that bother you, and should it?*

Then choose from these.

- Why do we let anyone come to the table? What would we lose if we fenced it, and what would we gain?
- Wesley said perfection means perfect love rather than flawlessness. Does that make the claim easier to believe, or does it feel like a technicality?
- Have you ever met someone you would describe as holy? What were they actually like? Do not name them if you would rather not.
- Three traditions say holiness does not finish in this life and we say it can. Who do you think is right?
- Is Wesley's claim wonderful, or is it a setup for despair? Both readings have long histories inside Methodism.
- What would you say to a grandchild who was told her baptism did not count?

Hold in reserve, and this is the best twenty minutes available in the series: *If entire sanctification is actually possible, then the Christian life is not a holding pattern until you die. What would change about this week if you believed you could be made new rather than only forgiven?*

Let that one run. If it takes the last twelve minutes, let it take them.

Close (2 minutes)

Next week we find out what all five weeks of this actually change about how a church works.

Between now and next Sunday

Ten minutes. Watch "Water of Life" (4:57) at bibleproject.com/videos/water-of-life. Then one question: if water is God's image for life given rather than earned, what does that suggest about baptizing someone who cannot yet ask for it?

Thirty minutes. Read Wesley's *A Plain Account of Christian Perfection*, free online. Skim if you must, but read the sections where he lists what he does not mean. He was answering people who had misheard him, and their misunderstandings are still the ones we have.

Go deeper. Read the sacraments chapter of Ted Campbell's *Methodist Doctrine: The Essentials*, or the corresponding chapter of Maddox's *Responsible Grace* if you want the serious version. Then open the Sacraments and Sanctification nodes on theologybot.vercel.app. Ask the bot: "What has Woods said about the open table?"

Bring back: one question about baptism or communion you have wanted to ask for years and have never asked.

Watch out for

The word perfection will do damage if you leave it undefined for even five minutes. Define it before you use it, and define it twice.

The other risk is the sacraments half eating the hour, because it is concrete and holiness is abstract. Watch the clock at 5:58 and move even if you are mid-sentence. Holiness is the reason this session exists.

Week 6 | September 27

Practical Theology

Women in ministry, polity, and mission

The question: Now that you know where everybody stands, what does it actually change about how a church works?

The one thing to land: Doctrine is not decoration. Every difference we have studied for five weeks shows up in something a church actually does on a Tuesday.

There is no room to spill

September 27 is the last night. October 4 is Commitment Sunday and the first meeting of the Sermon By Committee Study. Three topics in a shortened lecture means about ten minutes each, and women in ministry will happily eat the whole hour if you let it. Set a timer if you have to.

The hour

5:30	Opening question and video
5:38	Movement 1: women in ministry
5:48	Movement 2: polity, and who is allowed to do what
5:58	Movement 3: mission, and what counts as done
6:08	Discussion and closing the series
6:28	Close, and communion if you can arrange it

Open (8 minutes)

The opening question: *What have you actually been asked about our church that you could not answer?*

Write the answers on the board. Some you will get to tonight and some you will not, and it is better to say which is which than to pretend.

Video: “Justice” (6:18), Biblical Themes series.

bibleproject.com/videos/justice

Why this one: it sets up movement three, which is the part of tonight nobody has ever taught these people. Biblical justice as putting things right rather than as a political program is the frame the missiology conversation needs, and it lands better coming from a video than from a Methodist pastor in an election season.

After the video, ask: *Did that sound like evangelism, or like something else?* Take two answers and hold the thread.

Movement 1 (10 minutes) | Women in ministry

You already have this written. The plain-language essay in your folder is the right handout for this room.

The shape of the argument. The case against rests on two short passages. The case for rests on the rest of the canon. Deborah led Israel as prophet and judge. Huldah authenticated the recovered scroll for a king. Daughters prophesy at Pentecost. Priscilla taught Apollos. Phoebe carried Romans. Junia is called an apostle. And women were sent first from the empty tomb, in a culture where their testimony was not admissible in court.

Then the two passages, handled honestly rather than dodged. In 1 Corinthians, Paul gives instructions three chapters earlier for how women should pray and prophesy in the assembly, so the silence line cannot be an absolute rule. In 1 Timothy, the letter addresses a false-teaching problem, the word rendered “have authority” appears only there in the New Testament and carried a sense of seizing authority not given, and Paul’s first instruction in that very passage is that women should learn.

Where they stand.

- **Roman Catholic.** Ordination reserved to men, and the reasoning is different in kind rather than in degree. It is sacramental and christological rather than a reading of the two Pauline passages, which means an argument that works against a Baptist does not touch it. Say this plainly, because most people assume every tradition is arguing from the same two verses.
- **Southern Baptist.** The Baptist Faith and Message limits the office of pastor to men, and it is enforced. The convention expelled Saddleback Church in 2023 over women serving as pastors and rejected its appeal at that June’s annual meeting.
- **Non-denominational.** Ranges widely, and the practice is often complementarian even where nobody can point to a document saying so.
- **Reformed.** Split down the middle. The PCA does not ordain women. The PCUSA does. Same family tree.
- **Us.** Full clergy rights since 1956, and Wesley licensed women to preach in his own lifetime.

The slippery-slope objection, answered directly because someone will raise it. The claim is that ordaining women leads a church to abandon Scripture elsewhere. Point at the Church of the Nazarene, the Free Methodists, the Wesleyan Church, the Salvation Army, and the Global Methodist Church. All ordain women. None has slid. If the slope were real it would have shown up by now.

Movement 2 (10 minutes) | Polity, and who is allowed to do what

The sleeper of the whole series. Nobody teaches polity and everybody feels it.

First, who governs.

- **Roman Catholic.** Hierarchical. Bishops in apostolic succession, the pope, and a parish that belongs to a diocese.
- **Southern Baptist and non-denominational.** Congregational. The local church is autonomous. It calls and can dismiss its own pastor, owns its own building, and cooperates voluntarily.
- **Reformed.** Presbyterian. Elders governing through graded courts, session and presbytery and general assembly.
- **Us.** Connectional and episcopal. Bishops appoint, pastors itinerate, the annual conference is the basic body, and property is held in trust.

Then the part that surprises people. Ask the room who is allowed to serve communion and watch them realize they do not know.

- **Roman Catholic.** The sharpest line of the four. Only a priest consecrates. Laity serve in many roles and that function is reserved.
- **Southern Baptist and non-denominational.** The priesthood of all believers taken furthest in practice. Deacons are lay, the congregation holds authority over the pastor rather than the other way around, and in many churches a layperson can preside at the Supper.
- **Reformed.** Genuinely surprising to most Methodists. Ruling elders are laypeople and they govern alongside the teaching elder. A Presbyterian session is mostly laity with real authority, not an advisory board.
- **Us.** Elders, deacons, licensed local pastors, certified lay ministers, lay servants and lay speakers. Communion is presided over by clergy, with a bishop able to authorize a licensed local pastor within a charge. And the annual conference seats lay and clergy members in equal numbers, which is a Methodist distinctive worth saying out loud.

Make it concrete, because this is where it lands. Your neighbor's church can fire its pastor and ours cannot. Ours can be assigned a pastor it did not choose. Their building belongs to them and ours is held in trust. A Methodist congregation is never on its own, which is a burden on the

Sundays you would rather be and a lifeline in the year you cannot make budget.

Then the honest tradeoff. Congregational polity maximizes local freedom and gives a church no protection when it goes wrong. Connectional polity gives protection and costs local control. Neither is obviously correct and both are guarding something real.

Movement 3 (10 minutes) | Mission, and what counts as done

The question: What is the church actually sent to do, and what counts as having done it?

Where we stand, and notice the throughline back to week three. If prevenient grace is true, God is already at work in every person and every place before the church arrives. You are not carrying God into a place where he is absent. You are joining what he already started and naming it. That one conviction shapes the whole Methodist approach.

Which is why Methodism has never been able to separate evangelism from social reform. Wesley preached in fields and he also worked on prisons, on poverty, and against the slave trade, and he did not experience those as two programs. American Methodism institutionalized that instinct in the Social Creed in 1908. The modern frame most of the church now shares is *missio Dei*, the mission is God's before it is ours and the church participates rather than owns.

Where they stand.

- **Roman Catholic.** Mission as the church extending its own sacramental life, and since Vatican II an explicit joining of proclamation with justice. Catholic social teaching is a developed body of doctrine most Protestants have never read, and the preferential option for the poor is a theological commitment rather than a program. Rome is also the largest provider of schools, hospitals, and relief in the world, which is mission as institution-building over centuries.
- **Southern Baptist and non-denominational.** Conversion-centered, with the Great Commission as the organizing text and personal witness as the ordinary means. Enormous, disciplined, and effective. The International Mission Board is among the largest sending agencies anywhere, and church planting is the primary strategy. The metric is professions of faith and baptisms.
- **Reformed.** Mission as obedience rather than anxiety, which follows directly from week three. If God will certainly save his elect, the missionary is not carrying the outcome on his back. Alongside that runs a Kuyperian instinct toward cultural transformation, the

conviction that every sphere of life belongs to Christ, which produces schools and institutions and a long view.

Bring it home before you stop. Community Dinner, the tutoring partnership with the literacy council, Church Serve Day, and the thrift store are all answers to tonight's question whether or not anyone framed them that way.

On screen (2 minutes). Open the **per-tradition mind maps** at theologycompare.vercel.app and show one tradition spun out whole, then another. After five weeks of comparing single doctrines, seeing one tradition assembled as a coherent system is the right last image. Then step back and look at the wall map, six weeks of marks on it, and let the room see what they built.

Discussion (20 minutes)

Open with: *Which of the six weeks changed something for you?*

Then choose from these.

- What is the hardest question you have been asked about this church?
- Who should be allowed to do what in a church, and why? Where did your instinct about that come from?
- What counts as mission accomplished? A convert, a transformed neighborhood, a hospital that runs for a hundred years, a person fed?
- Has knowing another tradition better made you more Methodist or less?
- Being connectional means we are protected and we are not free. Which of those two do you feel more often?
- What would you tell someone who asked why you are here rather than somewhere else?

The closing exercise, and give it eight minutes. Bring back Wesley's catholic spirit and the essentials-and-opinions distinction from January, now with six weeks of concrete disagreement on the table rather than as an abstraction. Put the question to the room:

Sort the list. Of everything we have studied, what actually divides the church of Jesus Christ, and what is a matter on which Christians hold liberty?

Let them argue. They will not all agree, which is the point, and a room that has spent six weeks learning to state other people's positions accurately should be able to disagree about this well. That is the exam, and it is the only one.

Meldenius, which you used in January: in essentials unity, in non-essentials liberty, and in all things charity.

Close

End at the table if you can arrange it. Six weeks of studying difference, closing at the one table we keep open to anybody who wants to come. That is the argument of the whole series in a form nobody has to explain.

After the series

Keep going. Read Adam Hamilton's *Christianity's Family Tree* if you have not, or Don Thorsen's *Calvin vs. Wesley*. Both sites stay up and stay free. And the Sermon By Committee Study starts next Sunday at 5:30 in this room, where instead of studying what the church has decided we work on the text together before I preach it.

Watch out for

Two things. First, the clock. Women in ministry can absorb the entire hour, and the other two topics are the ones nobody has ever taught these people.

Second, do not let the last hour become a defense of the denomination in a hard season. The class is about the Christian faith as Methodists hold it. That is a bigger and better subject than the institution, and the room will feel the difference.

What Do You Actually Believe?

Final night, September 27

Sacraments, women in ministry, and polity

Sunday 5:30 to 7:00 PM, West Campus. Ninety minutes. The week 5 material the room never got, folded together with the two most practical pieces of week 6.

The question on the table: What does any of this change about what a church actually does?

The one thing to land: Doctrine isn't decoration. What we believe about grace decides who gets baptized, who gets to preach, and who gets to decide.

Provenance

Nearly all of tonight is yours already. The sacraments movement is your week 5 session compressed and taught off your January chart. The women-in-ministry movement is your June 19 pastor's note and the longer essay behind it. Polity is your week 6 movement 2 as written. The few things I added from memory are marked [Memory]. Anything from your own files is unmarked.

The ninety minutes

TIME	MOVE	MINUTES
5:30	Welcome, the opening question, the video	10
5:40	Movement 1: what God does at the font and the table	15
5:55	Movement 2: women in ministry	15
6:10	Movement 3: polity, and who's allowed to do what	15
6:25	Discussion and the closing exercise	25
6:50	Close at the table	10

Movement 2 is the one that will try to eat the hour. It has the most emotional charge and you know it best. Set a timer at 5:55 and move at 6:10 even mid-sentence. Polity is the thing nobody has ever taught these people, and it's where your own view of authority becomes concrete.

What to bring. The screen pack (Final-Night-Screens.pdf, eleven pages, one per screen), which carries every table for the night plus the baptism timeline. Your January four-model chart, which the room already has; screen 2 is a clean version of the same four models if you'd rather put it on the TV. Elements for communion.

OPEN (10 MINUTES)

Opening question: *When a baby gets baptized here, what just happened?*

Same question you wrote for week 5. The room will be less sure than they expect to be, and the uncertainty is the door. Don't rescue them.

Video: "Holiness" (6:35), Biblical Themes series. bibleproject.com/videos/holiness. Download it before you leave the house.

Why this one, even though sanctification gets only a few minutes tonight: it shows holiness as God's own life rather than a behavior chart. That's the frame that makes "means of grace" make sense. The sacraments are how that life gets into a person.

After the video, ask: *Was holiness in that video mostly about behavior, or mostly about something else?* Take two answers.

MOVEMENT 1 (15 MINUTES) | WHAT GOD DOES AT THE FONT AND THE TABLE

Screens 1 to 5 carry this movement. Teach the four models off screen 2 or your January chart, and say you're reusing it. Calling back to January reads as a throughline. The arrows are the lesson: in each model, where does the Spirit's work land, in the elements, in the recipient, or in the meeting of the two?

What a means of grace is (4 minutes). Screen 1. Wesley's definition from Sermon 16, which you taught in January: outward signs, words, or actions ordained of God as the ordinary channels by which he conveys grace. Two things hold together. Grace is truly given here, which is more than a symbol. And it isn't automatic, which is less than a machine. Maddox's name for the whole system is responsible grace.

Then walk the four models by their arrows. Certain sacrament, model one: Rome and Orthodoxy, where the grace is in the rite itself when no obstacle is placed in the way. Certain sacrament, model two: Lutherans, a different account of the same certainty. Symbolic testimony: Baptists and Anabaptists, where the arrow points at the recipient's faith and the elements stay a sign, which is why they say ordinance and the word choice is the entire argument. Contingent sacrament: Presbyterians, Anglicans, and us, where grace is truly offered through the elements and truly has to be received, so the arrow runs both ways. The thing that surprises people: on this chart the Presbyterians are in our box and not the Baptists'.

The font (5 minutes). Read Romans 6:1-4 and Acts 2:38-39.

Infants are baptized because grace precedes response. That's prevenient grace applied with water, and it ties straight back to week three. And it isn't automatic, which is why the congregation makes vows. Somebody carries the promise until the child can carry it.

Screen 4: the baptism timeline. Two things on it you verified in Logos and the corpus two weeks ago, so say them with confidence:

- The Didache, the oldest church manual we have, prefers running water and then permits pouring on the head three times. The condition is the absence of the preferred water, not a shortage of it. So pouring is as old as the manual.
- Wesley's own Treatise on Baptism says it is performed "by washing, dipping, or sprinkling" because Scripture doesn't settle which. That's his sentence, in *Works* volume 10.

Where they stand, screen 3, and point back at the arrows as you go: Rome, a regenerating sacrament. The Reformed, a covenant sign in continuity with circumcision. Baptists, believer's baptism by immersion as testimony to something that already happened, which is why they can't count an infant baptism.

The table (5 minutes). Screen 3 again. Read 1 Corinthians 11:23-29.

Real presence without a defined mechanism. Rome defines it. Baptists call it a memorial. The Reformed hold a real spiritual presence received by faith. We affirm the presence and decline to explain it, which is either humility or evasion depending on who you ask, and the room should get to say which.

Then the open table, which is a conviction rather than a technicality. Wesley treated communion as a converting ordinance. It can be the thing that reaches a person rather than only the reward for having been reached. We don't check credentials at the rail because we don't know who God is about to get hold of. Tonight ends at that table, so plant the line now.

The one-minute coda, and it's the reason week 5 existed. Means and end. The sacraments are channels. Holiness is what they're for. And on holiness we're the outlier: Rome, the Reformed, and the Baptists all say it doesn't finish in this life, and Wesley said it can. Perfect love, not flawlessness, and he spent years saying what he didn't mean. Screen 5 is the table. Say it in two sentences and offer it as a conversation you'd love to have with anyone who wants it. If you'd rather cut the coda to protect the clock, cut it, but don't let the series end without the room hearing that we make a claim nobody else makes.

MOVEMENT 2 (15 MINUTES) | WOMEN IN MINISTRY

You already wrote this. The June 19 pastor's note is the right script and the right handout. What follows is the order that fits fifteen minutes.

Start with the frame, because the frame is the argument (2 minutes). Most arguments against women in ministry rest on two short passages. The fairer question is what the whole of Scripture shows. Say that sentence before you say a single verse, because once the conversation narrows to dueling readings of 1 Timothy 2, whoever holds the restriction gets to call his reading the plain meaning and yours a workaround.

The witnesses (4 minutes). Screen 6. Deborah led Israel as prophet and judge, and the army commander did what she told him. Huldah authenticated the recovered scroll for a king. Daughters prophesy at Pentecost. Priscilla taught Apollos. Phoebe is a deacon of Cenchreae, the same word Paul uses for himself and for Timothy, and she carried Romans and almost certainly read it to the church first. Junia is called an apostle, and she was read as a woman for the first thousand years. And the risen Christ sent women first, in a culture where their testimony wasn't admissible in court.

The two hard texts, handled rather than dodged (4 minutes). In 1 Corinthians, Paul tells women how to pray and prophesy out loud three chapters before he tells them to be silent, so the silence can't be absolute and the chapter is about disorder. In 1 Timothy, the letter is about people teaching before they've learned; Paul's first instruction is that women should learn, and the word for "authority" shows up nowhere else in the New Testament and carried a sense of seizing power that wasn't given. Read in context he's keeping untrained people out of the teacher's chair.

The Wesleyan piece (2 minutes). God hands out gifts through the Spirit, and ordination is the church recognizing gifts already given. Wesley watched Sarah Crosby and Mary Bosanquet preach, saw the fruit, and recognized what he called an extraordinary call. Be precise: he never ordained a woman, and if you overstate him a sharp listener will catch it. Phoebe Palmer argued the biblical case at book length in 1859. Full clergy rights came May 4, 1956, seventy years ago this year. This isn't a 1960s drift. It's a 250-year-old instinct.

Where they stand (2 minutes). Screen 7. Rome reserves ordination to men on sacramental and christological grounds, not on the two Pauline passages, so an argument that works against a Baptist doesn't touch it. Say that plainly. The Southern Baptist Convention limits the pastorate to men and enforces it; it expelled Saddleback in 2023, and this past June in Orlando it advanced an amendment to tighten the restriction further. The Reformed are split down the middle, PCA no and PCUSA yes. Us: full clergy rights since 1956.

The slippery slope, in one breath. The Nazarenes, the Free Methodists, the Wesleyan Church, the Salvation Army, and the Global Methodist Church all ordain women and hold traditional teaching elsewhere. If the slope were real it would have shown by now.

End where your note ended. Some good and serious Christians read those two passages differently. When God calls a woman and gives her the gifts, our job is to say yes to what God is already doing.

MOVEMENT 3 (15 MINUTES) | POLITY, AND WHO'S ALLOWED TO DO WHAT

The sleeper of the whole series. Nobody teaches polity and everybody feels it. And it's where tonight's first two movements land, because who baptizes and who preaches are both questions of who decides.

Who governs (5 minutes). Screen 8.

- Rome: hierarchical. Bishops in succession, the pope, a parish that belongs to a diocese.
- Baptist and non-denominational: congregational. The local church is autonomous. It calls and can dismiss its own pastor, owns its building, cooperates voluntarily.
- Reformed: presbyterian. Elders governing through graded courts.
- Us: connectional and episcopal. Bishops appoint, pastors itinerate, the annual conference is the basic body, property is held in trust.

The part that surprises people (5 minutes). Ask the room who's allowed to serve communion and watch them realize they don't know. Then screen 9.

- Rome: only a priest consecrates. The sharpest line of the four.
- Baptist: the priesthood of all believers taken furthest. Deacons are lay, the congregation holds authority over the pastor, and in many churches a layperson can preside at the Supper.
- Reformed: the one that surprises Methodists. Ruling elders are laypeople who govern alongside the teaching elder. A session is mostly laity with real authority.
- Us: elders, deacons, licensed local pastors, certified lay ministers, lay servants. Clergy preside at communion, and a bishop can authorize a licensed local pastor within a charge. The annual conference seats lay and clergy in equal numbers, which is worth saying out loud.

Make it concrete (3 minutes). Your neighbor's church can fire its pastor and ours can't. Ours can be assigned a pastor it didn't choose. Their building belongs to them and ours is held in trust. A Methodist congregation is never on its own, which is a burden on the Sundays you'd rather be and a lifeline in the year you can't make budget.

The honest tradeoff (2 minutes). Congregational polity maximizes local freedom and gives a church no protection when it goes wrong. Connectional polity gives protection and costs local control. Neither is obviously correct and both are guarding something real. And then the sentence that ties the night together: every one of tonight's three questions was settled somewhere by somebody with the authority to settle it. The polity is where the authority lives.

On screen (2 minutes, only if the clock allows). The per-tradition mind maps at theologycompare.vercel.app, one tradition spun out whole and then another. After six weeks of comparing single doctrines, one tradition assembled as a system is the right last image. Then the wall map with six weeks of marks on it.

DISCUSSION AND THE CLOSING EXERCISE (25 MINUTES)

Open with: *Which of the six weeks changed something for you?*

Then choose from these.

- Do you remember your own baptism? If not, does that bother you, and should it?

- Why do we let anyone come to the table? What would we lose if we fenced it, and what would we gain?
- What would you say to a grandchild who was told her baptism didn't count?
- Have you ever sat under a woman's preaching and forgotten to notice? What does that tell you?
- Where did your instinct about who's allowed to do what in a church come from? Was it ever taught to you, or did you absorb it?
- Being connectional means we're protected and we're not free. Which of those do you feel more often?
- Has knowing another tradition better made you more Methodist or less?

The closing exercise, and give it ten minutes. Screen 10. Bring back Wesley's catholic spirit and the essentials-and-opinions distinction from January, now with six weeks of concrete disagreement on the table. Put it to the room:

Sort the list. Of everything we've studied, what actually divides the church of Jesus Christ, and what's a matter on which Christians hold liberty?

Let them argue. They won't all agree, which is the point. A room that has spent six weeks learning to state other people's positions accurately should be able to disagree about this well. That's the exam, and it's the only one.

Meldenius, which you used in January: in essentials unity, in non-essentials liberty, and in all things charity.

CLOSE AT THE TABLE (10 MINUTES)

Six weeks of studying difference, closing at the one table we keep open to anybody who wants to come. That's the argument of the whole series in a form nobody has to explain. Before the words of institution, one sentence: everything you learned tonight about who's allowed to preside is why I'm standing here, and everything you learned about the open table is why you are.

After the series. Adam Hamilton's *Christianity's Family Tree*, or Don Thorsen's *Calvin vs. Wesley*. Both sites stay up and stay free. Next Sunday is Commitment Sunday in the morning, and the Sermon By Committee Study starts at 5:30 in this room.

WATCH OUT FOR

The clock, twice. Women in ministry at 6:10 and the closing exercise at 6:40. If you're behind at 6:25, shorten the prompts and protect the sort.

The word perfection. If the holiness coda survives, define perfect love before you say the word perfection, or skip the word entirely. An undefined "perfection" does damage in under five minutes.

Your own authorship argument. Your oldest form of the women-in-ministry position, in the 2016 ordination Bible study, runs on the difference between the real Paul and the writer of 1 Timothy. Your pastor's note and essay don't use that move, and for this room that's the right call. Half the case's power comes from taking 1 Timothy as Paul's and reading it in context anyway. If someone raises pseudonymity, answer briefly and return to the canon argument.

Rome on women. The most common error you'll hear is that Catholics forbid women's ordination because of 1 Timothy. They don't. Correct it kindly and immediately, per the house rule.

Don't defend the denomination. The class is about the Christian faith as Methodists hold it. That's a bigger subject than the institution, and in a hard season the room will feel the difference. Polity should sound like a description of a tradeoff, not a case for staying.

HAVE READY

"Isn't the open table disrespectful to the sacrament?" Wesley thought communion could be the thing that converts a person rather than only the reward for having been converted.

"Why do we baptize babies when the Bible says believe and be baptized?" Because we think grace comes before response. The same reason a baby is fed before she can ask.

"The Bible says women should be silent." Three chapters earlier the same letter tells them how to pray and prophesy out loud. Both can't be absolute, so the question is what problem chapter 14 was fixing.

"Wesley would never have ordained a woman." Correct, and say so. He authorized women to preach under an extraordinary call and stopped there. The church he started kept reading Scripture and went further, which is how Methodists think doctrine develops.

"So the bishop can just send us anybody?" Yes, in consultation, and the same system means this church has never once been without a pastor. Both halves are true.

Missiology, if it comes up. It was on the original week 6 plan and got cut for time. The short version: if prevenient grace is true, God is already at work everywhere before the church arrives, so Methodism has never been able to separate evangelism from social reform. Community Dinner, the literacy council partnership, Church Serve Day, and the thrift store are all answers to that question whether or not anyone framed them that way.